Chapter Sixty-Seven

The Southern and Northern Courts

Between 1318 and 1339,
the Kamakura shogunate falls,
the Ashikaga shogunate rises,
and the Chrysanthemum Throne
divides

THE MONGOL INVASION OF JAPAN had failed, twice. The island still lay safe off the coast, a protective wall of water between the samurai and the Mongol soldiers of the Yuan dynasty.

But Japan's convoluted, two-court arrangement was fragile; and in the aftershocks of the Mongol attacks, it shivered apart.

At the peak of the Mongol threat, the imperial court in Kyoto had divided over the succession to the Chrysanthemum Throne. A complicated argument between two brothers—one the oldest son of the emperor, the other his favorite—eventually resolved itself into an arrangement where the sons and grandsons of the older brother (the senior line) and the descendants of the younger alternated on the throne.

Like most compromises, this one made everyone unhappy. The two royal families grew increasingly hostile to each other. The junior line followed Confucianism, the senior Buddhism; the junior line patronized Chinese-style scholarship, the senior preferred Japanese literature written in traditional Japanese script. Within the clans, individual families quarreled over the right